

A few tips from one man to the liberated male

ARE you confused and uncertain? Do you need a new Charlotte Ford, a new Emily Post to advise you on polite behaviour?

We have just been told that Australian men are struggling. They do not know how to come to terms with the modern assertive woman.

Must she still be treated as a helpless little flower?

Mr Robert Freak, the director of the Centre of Personal Encounter in Adelaide, says that many men are uncertain of the "how ya goin, love" approach and are even unsure whether to open doors for women.

You are very fortunate. It just so happens your correspondent has

That's life
Keith Dunstan

been able to get hold of a preview copy of the 1985 edition of Emily Dunstan's *Guide To Polite Behaviour and Exquisite Social Custom*.

Just flipping through the pages, here are some of the more interesting problems likely to be encountered by men today.

Q: Do you raise your hat to a lady?

A: Of course. Your hair-do cost \$45 at the Unisex hairdresser, you will have no desire to keep it a secret.

Q: Who walks on the outside of the pavement, male or female?

A: Wise males always walk on the inside. It keeps the female away from the shop windows.

Q: Is it okay for girls to call boys on the telephone and invite them out on dates?

A: Yes, but it is not good etiquette to reverse the charges.

Q: What should we wear on a first date?

A: Dress up a bit, like wearing socks with your sneakers.

Q: Should you introduce the boy to the girl or the girl to the boy?

A: It does not matter. The important thing is to use christian names. This helps to identify the sexes.

Q: Should you shake hands upon being introduced?

A: Yes, it is improper to kiss until you have known each other at least 15 minutes.

Q: Should the male offer to carry parcels for a lady?

A: No. This applies to most physical acts like chopping wood or pushing stalled automobiles. Almost certainly the lady is doing a course in body building or weightlifting and wants the physical exercise.

Q: Is it improper to wear a hat inside a house or a restaurant?

A: No. Hats are not for keeping head warm or cool any more. They are your symbol of exotic masculinity. Wear it at all times.

Q: Who pays when you go out on a date?

A: It's simple. Whoever has a job.

Q: Is it acceptable in nice society for a spinster to live with a male?

A: Yes, but they might have to look up spinster in a dictionary. Nor do you use such horrid words outside the Taxation Department. Spurn indecicate words like mistress and de facto. It is acceptable to use live-in buddy, cohabitor or stablemate.

Q: Who does the washing up?

A: In tribal society the one who cooks is liberated from the washing up.

Q: What about night watch?

A: It is fair dos that the male does the first nappy change at 2 am.

Q: Should you be a gentleman and run side by side when jogging?

A: Yes, if you can keep up.

Q: Should a young female go out unaccompanied in the evening?

A: Yes, if she is good at karate.

Q: At what time should a young female return home in the morning?

A: Pretty darned early if she is using Dad's car.

Q: What do you do when you invite unmarried "good friends" to stay, especially when one is your daughter? Do you give them separate rooms?

A: You bet. It's nice to have separate rooms to spread your clothes. They will end up in one bed anyway.

Q: Do you stand up when a lady comes into the room?

A: Of course. It is the one way to get a better look at her.

Q: What are the rules for polite hospitality?

A: Tell them where the bathroom is; give them a glass and not a can; at least turn down the TV; and do not say at 11 pm, "Dear, have you turned on the electric blankets?"

A: Is it improper to go nude on the beach?

A: No, but make sure you lie on a pretty towel.

Q: Could you please advise on modern table manners?

A: Just like eating asparagus you use fingers for eating fast foods, hamburgers, fried chicken and dim sims. Use your right hand, not two. Handle your paper serviette daintily and dispose of your own paper plates.

Q: Is it socially correct for a female to propose marriage to a male?

A: Absolutely. We might be entering into a beautiful new era when either sex proposes marriage.

Q: Do you go hot with shame if he or she uses bad words?

A: No, but you get bored out of your mind if he or she keeps using them.

So you are still worried about opening and closing doors.

The liberated female gets nervous when the male dashes to open the door. Always allow her to open every second door. Find self-opening doors so that you can walk through side by side.

And how about standing up for people in the bus?

Hell, I was frightened you were going to ask that. Well, not often in 1984. I gaze upon the creature no matter what age, and if he or she is on crutches and putting on a good Academy Award act I might just do it.

A less formal way of teaching musical appreciation to children is paying off. Margo Beasley reports.

The younger the better to learn music

IN HER large and comfortable workroom, Phyl Lobl is surrounded by musical instruments, books, sheet music, recording equipment and a much-used photocopier.

"Musical education really starts with a baby in the womb," she says. "The foetus responds to sounds, voices and music."

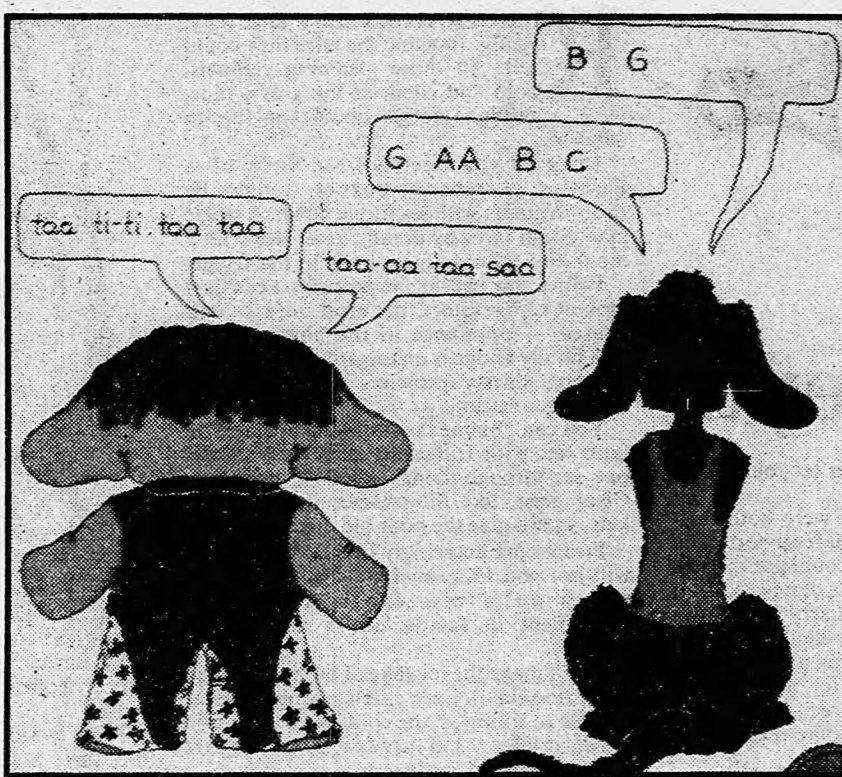
Mrs Lobl has been well known in the Australian folk scene as a writer and performer of folk music for nearly 20 years. A member of the Music Board of the Australia Council, her talents are now largely devoted to the musical education of children and, to the same end, their parents and teachers.

She gives a special federally-funded music program at a disadvantaged inner-western primary school, and also researches and conducts workshops on lullabies, dandling (amusement) songs, and body play (body awareness) songs for parents and child-care workers. These activities are intended to help fill a gap in Australian homes where very little music is performed or sung live.

The addition of a step-grandchild to her household stimulated her interest in lullabies. "If I minded the baby, naturally I sang lullabies to him. I realised that sometimes mothers are pretty tense and if they want the child to go to sleep it won't because it feels the tension in the mother. If I sang a lullaby the baby relaxed, but so did I."

The value of lullabies, though, is not only in getting the child to sleep and calming the mother. "It is probably the first musical experience for the baby."

Mrs Lobl began to write material for her step-grandson and to collect lullabies, dandling songs and body-play songs from her own childhood, friends, books and other sources.



She gave her first workshop on the subject for the Women and Arts Festival in 1982. A program was produced by the ABC and subsequent interest indicated the need for a cassette because workshops can only introduce the material, not teach it. She sings unaccompanied on the cassette, just as the songs would be sung in the home.

When she asked 250 of her school students, "Who in your house sings?", 200 replied, "No one." This does not mean that no music is ever played in the home but much of what the children

hear is what she terms "media music". "I ask the kids to sing me a Boy George song or a Michael Jackson song and they can't. It might be their favourite music but they can't reproduce it. For that reason most media music can never become folk music," she said.

The core of her work, she says, is that it first explains musical concepts in a visual way and returns later to teach particular skills. The visual element is a departure from more conventional music teaching. "My very good infant teacher training in Melbourne taught

me to use all the facilities available, visual as well as aural, to teach something," she said.

To this end she produced a kit containing a children's book, *Not Just Noise*, and a teacher's manual and cassette, aimed at "primary teachers who know nothing about music and music teachers who know nothing about children."

Of her work with the 600 children in the school Mrs Lobl says, "My aim for the first year was to get every child singing on pitch and to get them to be creative about music, realising that they too can make music." She admits to not having quite got them all on pitch, but the year is not finished yet.

A small number of people are unable to sing on pitch for physical reasons, she says, but it's mostly a listening problem, not a singing one. "If the parent sings out of tune, the child is likely to sing out of tune unless it has contact with people who sing in tune. Some may need to be shown how to listen or perhaps be given some muscular development."

"I have a big thing about finding a singing voice — the kids come up to me and say, 'Mrs Lobl, I found my singing voice last night' — they realise that they weren't really singing, they were talking." Even so, a problem with pitch is not the be-all and end-all of musical participation. Rhythmic work can be performed or an instrument played, so long as the child has pitch awareness.

She also employs visual methods. "I use different lengths of PVC piping with table tennis balls stuck in the ends to show that a whole note is equal to two half notes, for instance."

Her method involves singing, movement, creative music, musical appreciation and learning to read musical symbols. "It's a language," she says.

The activities are graded according to the ages of the children.

Grade 2 moves on to creative work such as sound stories where they will use instruments or their bodies to make sounds representing picture stories from the book. They may also reproduce patterns from the book. For example, four colours will be represented by four instruments and the children might choose which instrumental sound best represents a particular pattern.

The formal teaching of musical skills begins in grade 3 and, she says, "they lap it up. We can only afford recorders at the moment but by the time they get to grade 6 you can utilise that formal knowledge for creative work again. By then they can choose what they want to do, form little ensembles for example."

Mrs Lobl says she is not interested in simply producing a beautiful choir. "There's no way I want to form a choir until every child in that school has a chance to be part of it."

She is very happy with the results so far. "I wrote my book out of my experiences with partially-sighted children, but I hadn't proved my method in a primary school. I'm proving that now. I build the foundations very slowly. I don't rush in and teach everyone the recorder in first term."

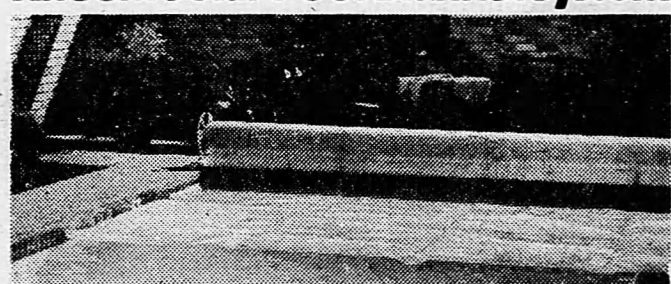
For Mrs Lobl the development of a musically-aware community means "a better chance of developing a culture which is relevant to our society, a society which is then more likely to deal with reality."

The musical education we have now, she says, is fine for producing instrumentalists and singers. But to develop our own musical culture we need a system which will produce composers so that creative work will originate in Australia.

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